of life, I thought it was ugly... morally ugly. It was the constant mistreatment of other people. Because I could understand the comparison, I refused to live that way. I dedicated all my efforts to making it possible not to live that way, for me and for you.

So in 1983, I launched the Free Software Movement, with the goal to make it possible to use computers and have freedom. However, for that to be a practical option, you needed an operating system that was free software. In the 1970s we had one, but it was PDP 10, which became obsolete in the early 80s; so all our software was obsolete too. And all the computer systems with modern software were proprietary.

To make free software a real option, we needed to be free—therefore, it was my job to develop it. I announced a plan to develop a UNIX-like OS that would be entirely free software. I gave it the name 'GNU', which stands for 'GNU's Not UNIX'. The name was kind of a joke—but the project was a very serious one, about fighting for freedom... freedom that we had lost completely.

Q What was the journey to develop GNU/Linux like?

We had to start from a point that was just a little more than zero, and work our way up to freedom. There were a few free programs in 1983 when I started GNU, but those were in no way near a whole OS. There was a lot of work to do, and during the 1980s, we did it. There are hundreds of components that you need to have a UNIX-like OS, even at the most basic level. A few components we found with somebody else, who wrote them for different reasons, but were free software. But the other components we had to develop. So I wrote some of them, and recruited people to write others, and in some cases, convinced people to develop free programs—for instance, the CSRG (Computer Systems Research Group) at Berkeley. They had written a lot of code to change UNIX, but their code was mixed in AT&T's code, and so was proprietary. I met them in 1984 and requested them to separate their software and release it as free, which they subsequently did. I wanted to use that code in the GNU system.

By 1992, we had almost the complete GNU system, but one essential component was missing: the kernel. We started developing one in 1990. I chose an advanced design, which gave it somewhat the character of a research project, and it took six years to get a test version. Unfortunately, nobody succeeds every time. But we didn't have to wait, because in February 1992, Linus Torvalds, who had a proprietary kernel called Linux, decided to make it free. The combination of the Linux kernel with the rest of the GNU system made a complete OS, which was basically GNU, but also contained Linux. So calling it only the Linux OS is wrong; it is the GNU/Linux OS.

Q Is the concept of Free Software anyway related to the price?

To me Free Software is the freedom issue, and not the price, which is a side issue. You may get a free copy of software, or you may pay for it; either is okay. The important thing is that Free Software respects your freedom and the community. When a program is non-free, we call it proprietary, non-free, user-subjugating software. A non-free program generates a system of digital colonisation. There is a colonial power, which is the proprietary software, and then there are colonised people, who are the users. Like any colonised system, the proprietary software keeps the people divided. They are helpless because they do not have the source code. They can't change it, and they can't even tell what it really does. Proprietary software is often designed to do something nasty.

> **"Many proprietary programs have malicious features. These features spy on users, and send their data somewhere.."**

Free Software is important for freedom in the community is a general statement, but let me be specific. A program that you have a copy of is free for you if you have four essential freedoms. Freedom '0' is to run the program as you wish. Freedom '1' is the freedom to study the source code and change it—so it does your computing as you wish. Freedom '2' is the freedom to help others to make copies of the software, and distribute them. Freedom '3' is the freedom to contribute to your community, to make copies of your modified versions, and distribute them to others if you wish. So, if a program comes with these four freedoms, it's Free Software, because the social system of its distribution and use is an ethical system that respects the freedom of the community.

If one of these freedoms is missing or insufficient, it is proprietary software, because it imposes an unethical social system on its users. So, the distinction between free and proprietary software is not a technical distinction. But this is a social, ethical and political distinction, which is why it is so important... more important in general than any technical distinction.

The use of proprietary software in society is not development; it's dependence. The use of proprietary software is a social problem. We should aim to put an end to it. Writing free programs is a contribution to society. So, if you have a choice between writing a proprietary software or doing nothing at all, you should do nothing at all—because that way, you don't do harm. Thus, the goal of the Free Software Movement is that all software should be free, so that their users can be free. Once you have understood this issue, you should make sure that you don't get into this. We should reject the propaganda terms that the developers of the proprietary software use to demonise the co-operation. I am referring to terms like 'pirates'. When they call people 'pirates', they mean that helping other people (by sharing software) is the moral equivalent of attacking ships.